

UTEW 221 V

SU3

**Postmodernism & Social
Justice education**

Postmodernism & Social Justice education

Learning outcomes

- explain what postmodernism entails;
- identify key concerns and characteristics of postmodernism;
- explain the relationship between postmodernism and social justice and diversity
- evaluate and assess the role and relevance of social justice in the educational world;
- discuss ways in which postmodernism and concepts such as social justice and diversity are related to complex problems in the educational world;
- discuss ways in which social justice and diversity can be promoted or defended in the contemporary educational world.

Postmodernism – an introduction

- Epistemological approaches do not exist independently. They are embedded in a larger web of suppositions referred to as worldviews.
- Worldviews entail certain philosophical assumptions about the nature of reality and how knowledge about that reality is ascertained, accumulated, and transferred from one group of individuals to another.
- In Western discourse, it is widely argued that two worldviews are particularly prominent. These worldviews are modernism and postmodernism (Hodge & Derezotes, 2008:104).
- Postmodernists would argue that educational approaches grounded in modernistic assumptions that privilege rational knowledge are ill-suited to convey a subjective, experientially-based knowledge form (Hodge & Derezotes, 2008:104).

Regarding postmodernist, the aims of education are teaching critical thinking, production of knowledge, development of individual and social identity, self creation. In postmodern education teachers just lead students to discover new things.

Postmodernism – an introduction

- That it is even possible to talk about postmodernist criticism is because of the conditions of modernity.
- The various theoretical positions associated with postmodernism mainly reflect a modernist scepticism toward traditions and received ‘foundations’ of truth” (Burbules, 2009:525).
- There seems to be a consensus that “searching about postmodernism without knowing modernism is impossible because postmodernism has refused most of modernism's main ideas” (Burbules, 2009:525).
- There is no consensus on what “postmodernism” really is. However, according to Nicholas Burbules, it has come to represent an “umbrella term” for varying theoretical positions.
- It could be argued, above all, that postmodernism “represents a certain kind of critical attitude, most often defined to what it is not.

Key concerns of Postmodernism

Postmodernism has been described as:

- a denial of metanarratives;
- a reaction against enlightenment values and rationality;
- an extreme form of antirealism or social constructivism;
- or a radical assertion of difference and non-normativity (Burbules, 2009:525).

Poststructuralism (or Deconstructionism)

- Associated with Jacques Derrida and Michel Foucault.
- Poststructuralists seem to subvert the foundations of language and show that its seeming meaningfulness does not result in the communication of any definitive meaning. This school is most often associated with Jacques Derrida.
- Michel Foucault: “Where do we get our beliefs about normality anyway?” Such beliefs were inculcated into us by modern institutions (e.g., schools) which monitor us endlessly.

Social education justice goal

- Along with Critical Theory, Critical Race Theory, Feminist Theory and Multicultural Education theories, postmodernist theory advocate the social justice education goal.
- The common theme among social justice education theories is the call for institutions such as schools to expose and reconstruct oppressive policies and practices.
- Social justice theories coincide with social transmission theorists' contention that schools are primary tools in maintaining the status quo by teaching obedience and “compelling students to embrace the dominant culture, and sorting students according to capitalistic hierarchies”. (Mthethwa-Sommers).
- However, social justice theories argue that when schools serve as transmission tools of the dominant culture, they also serve to maintain inequities and social injustices that exist in society.
- Social justice education theories maintain that schools should serve as places of democracy “with all its inherent ideological, cultural, religious, and social diversity, and should serve toward social justice”, a key indicator of democracy.

Social justice education: envisions a society in which individuals are both self determining (able to develop their full capacities) and interdependent (capable of interacting democratically with others).

What is social justice for education?

Social justice is about distributing resources fairly and treating all students equitably so that they feel safe and secure—physically and psychologically. Sadly, a look at schools across the nation makes it clear that fair distribution of resources and equitable treatment don't always happen.

How postmodernism may influence ethics in the educational world

- Hybridity and the fluidity of differences may make for provocative theoretical discussions. But they distract from the fundamental divides in power and privilege that shape modern society, which need to be diagnosed clearly and challenged directly (Burbules, 2009:526-527).
- Politically, one must know whose side one is on and whom one is against (Burbules, 2009:526-527).
- According to Giroux (2004:38), educators need to be made accountable, ethically and politically, for the narratives they give as well as for the demands they make on what the public ought to remember as well as how they view the future.
- Giroux regards as critical that, when providing students with skills, knowledge and authority, they also need to think more deeply and be able to demonstrate what it means to live in a real democracy, able to spot anti-democratic forms of power and able to fight injustices that are deeply anchored in systemic economic, social, racial and gendered inequalities (Giroux, 2004:34).

How postmodernism affects educational world

- What we often conceive as truth and justice is usually reflective of privileged voices and not necessarily the standard (Burbules, 2009:528-9).
- As we have many different languages of which the words do not necessary mean exactly the same thing. According to Burbules (2009:527), expressions are always going to be specific to the language as well as place and time.
- According to Monisha Bajaj, asymmetrical power relationships and their roots (social, political, historical, and economic) create unequal forms of citizenship that education, and corresponding social action, must seek to disrupt (Monisha Bajaj, <http://www.tandfonline.com/loi/cjpe20>).
- It has been suggested that asymmetrical power can shape even some of our best intentions of trying to be more egalitarian, and this could happen across many structures of life, regardless of whether these are formal or informal (Burbules, 2009:527).

Why is postmodernism important in education?

Help students be aware that they part of a knowledge society, and this is through deepening the other cultures they have. Help students give their different opinions according their beliefs. Help students understand the nature of knowledge from different aspects such as social and historical aspects.



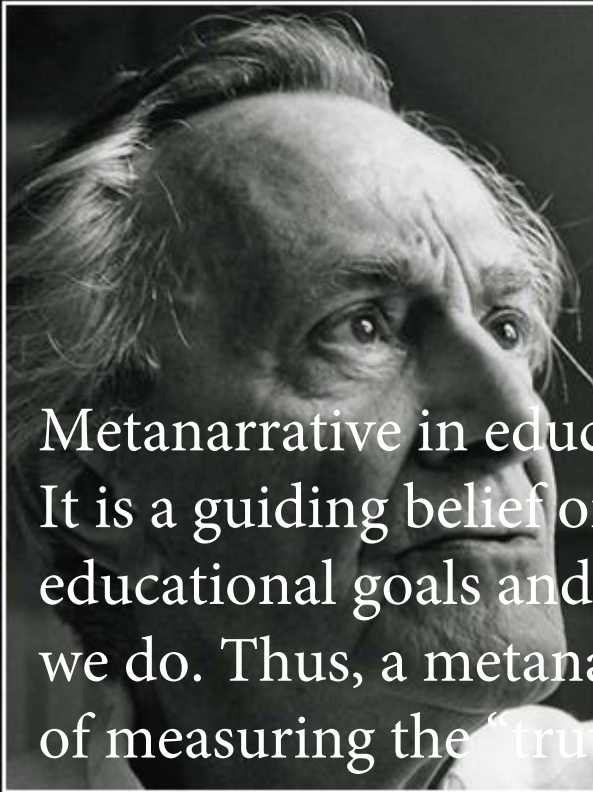
Where in the world are we going?

POSTMODERNISM

- Postmodernism is a philosophical mode of inquiry that raises important questions and challenges our faith in modernism. Postmodernism invites us to rethink our belief in science and scientific progress. For instance, what drives us as human beings? Do our lives have meaning outside of mere scientific discoveries? Are we all merely reasonable individuals? What about our desires, hopes, wishes, dreams, aspirations and nightmares?
- In short, Postmodernism is an attempt to shed some light on “what it means to be human”.

Are we all merely reasonable individuals? What about our desires, hopes, wishes, dreams, aspirations and nightmares? Can Modernity, which relies on science, explain these? What about the make-believe world of neon advertising screens, giant billboards and glass lifts, man-made lakes, aquariums, bird houses found in shopping malls, or images and dreams in the make-believe world of modern cinemas?

what about failed intimate relations, routine trouble with neighbours or colleagues at work, violent crime, racial unrest, rampant unemployment, widening gap between the rich and poor, political and religious fundamentalism? Postmodernism recognises that while these issues sound silly and trivial, and may not be scientifically explained, they do shed some light on “what it means to be human”



Simplifying to the extreme, I define
postmodern as incredulity toward
metanarratives.

— *Jean-François Lyotard* —

Metanarrative in education

It is a guiding belief or consensus that helps us set our educational goals and provides the rationale for doing what we do. Thus, a metanarrative is both a motivator and a way of measuring the “truth” or validity of what we are doing.

ALPHATTS



Postmodernism entices us with the
siren call of liberation and creativity,
but it may be an invitation to
intellectual and moral suicide.

— Gertrude Himmelfarb —

AZ QUOTES

OVERVIEW OF POSTMODERNISM

Postmodernism's disbelief in our powers of reasoning to liberate us, its radical scepticism and finally its rejection of all meta-narratives have made it either hated or loved in education and training institutions, depending on the emotions it evokes. Postmodernism defies definition, therefore there does not exist one definite definition for the concept"

Where does Postmodernism help us

- Re-assess the quality of our lives
- Resist the pressure to turn into workaholics
- Gain more creative energy
- Question the claims of rigid morality
- Lead freer lives

Where postmodernism fails us

- It may encourage destructive behaviour such as drug dependency
- It has not yet given us any alternatives to science as a way forward
- It under estimates the need for disciplined effort in any human endeavour.
- It can lead to despair
- It is elitist. It needs to simplify its language to become more accessible to non-intellectuals



Postmodernism

- Rethink our belief in science
- What drives us as human beings? Reason? Logic?
- What about desires, hopes, wishes, dreams even nightmares... not only science that is important?
- What narratives drive us?

POSTMODERNISM DOES NOT BELIEVE IN DEFINITIONS

- POST MODERNISM EXAMINES THE FOLLOWING ASPECTS:
- The way which we see ourselves
- The failure of sciences to solve many problems
- The fact that reason may not be a good guide to solving certain problems
- The power of large, modern institutes ,e.g.: schools, hospitals , large businesses etc. , over the individual
- The need to experience all our emotions
- Our inner needs
- Mental anguish
- Where we can get our standards of right and wrong.

